

Section 30: On the Usage and Definition of Concepts

As we conclude this massive, hundred-thousand-word chapter, it is inevitable that I have introduced original concepts, some of which may push the boundaries of conventional terminology. Therefore, I establish here the precise definitional criteria I apply to historical nomenclature, offering them to the reader for reference and rigorous critique.

Class vs. Stratum (阶级与阶层): Although the usage of "class" and "stratum" has long been conflated, I argue that a fundamental distinction must be maintained. I absolutely reject the notion of categorizing the state apparatus or the bureaucracy as a "class." In my view, the term "class" must denote that its subject is intrinsically linked to a specific *mode of production* (生产方式). That is to say, when a group of people is defined as a class, the defining characteristic of this set is that its "elements" universally adopt a specific mode of production to directly generate productive forces. It is precisely because classes participate in labor and production through various means that they can shape human civilization from technological, cultural, artistic, and relational perspectives. This actually echoes the consistent Marxist view that historical development is driven by the movement of various classes. Regarding the theoretical completeness of Marx and Engels' original framework, we need not outright deny it; rather, we should distill its authentic core from historical distortions (去伪存真), making it logically self-consistent and universally applicable.

Unlike a class, the state apparatus or bureaucracy is fundamentally *detached from material production* (脱产的). While one can certainly argue that it occupies a specific position within the relations of production, and even fulfills crucial social functions, it is emphatically *not* anchored to any specific mode of production. By drawing this line, we place the bureaucracy in a highly specific, separate position within the narrative of class analysis—a distinction that proves highly advantageous.

Similarly, one can observe that the elements within the set of "intellectuals" do not necessarily share a common mode of production. Therefore, they should be classified as an *intellectual stratum*, not an intellectual class. A salient difference between a class and a stratum is that classes emerge and are eliminated along with the evolution of eras—a process fundamentally determined by the birth and obsolescence of modes of production. Conversely, a stratum that performs a specific social function can persist for an exceedingly long time, because social functions do not necessarily vanish with the shifts in social formations brought about by class movements. There was a bureaucratic stratum and an intellectual stratum in the Sumerian period, just as there are in today's world, despite a span of five thousand years.

We must also note that a subset of a stratum can highly likely be classified as a class. While the stratum as a whole may lack a uniform mode of production, a specific segment of it might not. Take, for instance, the priests in early states. Setting aside their religious and administrative nature, priests—as a segment of intellectuals serving as a labor component—invested their knowledge into agricultural production and engineering construction. They did, indeed, generate productive forces through a specific mode of production. Therefore, designating priests as a "priestly class" is largely permissible. This explains why, when discussing the ruling classes of early states, priests are usually counted among their ranks.

Finally, I posit that merchants—specifically itinerant traders who are not responsible for producing goods but solely handle the circulation phase—should be viewed as a stratum rather than a class. As readers will see in the main text, this categorization is highly instrumental in explaining "trade-based pseudo-classical states" (贸易型伪古典国家) and "late-classical states." Furthermore, we must point out that while merchants are indispensable for their vital social function, they cannot serve as the primary creators of culture within a large-scale system. Only in societies like the Sogdian city-states—where the demographic scale is relatively small, yet situated on primary trade routes with an immense volume of trade—can commercial culture assume a dominant role.

Feudal economic system (封建经济制度): Refers to an economic system characterized by individual small-scale production as the primary production model, tenancy as the primary operational method, or—to phrase it more left-leaning—as the primary mode of exploitation (the above being the "feudal mode of production"), with pronounced features of a natural economy. The basic unit of economic production is generally the manor. The form of land rent undergoes changes with the development of the feudal economy; generally speaking, it transitions from in-kind to monetary. After feudal landlords at various levels achieve political dominance and become feudal lords, the feudal society should exhibit the characteristic of large-scale landownership, meaning that land, through various forms of annexation, reaches a high level of concentration. Serfdom exists to varying degrees; due to different specific environments, the strength of the peasants' dependence on the lords varies, but in any case, it is weaker than early slavery. The urban economy belonged as an appendage to the manor in the Early Middle Ages, but had already achieved a certain degree of independence in the High Middle Ages, with obvious development in long-distance commercial activities, monetary economy, and autonomy.

Manorial economy (庄园经济): No different from the definition universally used in academia.

Feudal political system (封建政治制度): The political system (spontaneously) organized after the feudal landlord class obtains political ruling power, based on the feudal economic system, using the High Middle Ages in England, France, and Germany as the standard. Its greatest characteristic is a distinctly hierarchical feudal power system, encompassing a series of rights and obligations; in particular, land ownership and relations of fealty possess a hereditary nature. Within the feudal system exists a military aristocracy acting as the middle and lower strata of the ruling class, translated as knights or samurai, whose maintenance of social status relies on military service.

It should be noted that the above two concepts use the High Feudal period as a standard. Feudal societies worldwide lasted for as short as four to five hundred years, or as long as over a millennium; obviously, there exists a process of development. For example, as already mentioned in the Beijing Section, judging from the situation of property inheritance systems, the entire feudal period witnessed a transition from partible inheritance to primogeniture. Therefore, under the premise of adhering to principles, actual judgments must also be analyzed in conjunction with specific circumstances. From a relatively broader perspective, under the condition where land is the *primary factor of production* (首位生产要素), any society where the landlord class emerges as the ruling class, completely obtains political dominance, and can enforce its will, belongs to a feudal society.

Quasi-feudal system (准封建制度): A political system that possesses characteristics of a feudal political system to a certain degree but has not reached the standards of a feudal political system, taking the Iqta system of the Islamic world and its various local variations as examples.

Feudal society (封建社会): A society that implements the feudal economic system and the feudal political system. The reason why it is only necessary to mention the two aspects of economy and politics is simply that as long as these two aspects are realized, all other factors will spontaneously adapt or emerge.

Feudal characteristics (封建特征): The characteristics in the economic, political, military, religious, and cultural fields possessed by a feudal society. The main content is precisely found within the feudal economic system and the feudal political system.

Feudal period (封建时期): The historical period during which feudal society exists.

Feudalism (封建主义): Although the word "ism" in China is heavily biased towards ideology and economic relations, when I mention feudalism, it refers to the collection of all characteristics of a feudal society, including economic systems, political systems, military service systems, prevailing religions, social concepts, and so on.

Feudalization (封建化): This concept is used by me to describe the entire process of the evolution of a feudal society; it emphasizes a trend of change.

Feudal landlord class (封建地主阶级): The ruling class in the feudal economic system, being the controllers of the means of production and the dominators of social production. However, when I use the concept of the feudal landlord class, it solely refers to the situation where it has failed to obtain political ruling power, such as in China during the restoration-bureaucratic period (复辟官僚时期) .

Feudal lord (封建领主): The feudal landlord class that has obtained ruling power politically; I mainly use this concept in feudal Europe and Japan.

Land ownership in the feudal period (封建时期的土地所有权): No matter what, even in typical feudal societies like Western Europe and Japan, the "land ownership" possessed by feudal lords could never be entirely identical to land ownership in the modern sense; nor could the legal concepts of pre-modern societies be as clear and perfected as those of modern societies. After all, a complete historical stage—the early modern period (近世)—separates feudal society from modern society, and the complexity of contemporary human society is entirely unimaginable compared to any previous historical period. Ultimately, the ownership of land by medieval feudal lords was still a type of *usufruct* (用益权) carrying attached obligations. If it were understood as an absolute right of disposal (绝对的支配权), then even the political phenomenon of multi-tiered subinfeudation (层层分封) would be difficult to explain. When we speak of "feudal lords acquiring land ownership," it

actually refers to the fact that feudal lords possessed highly comprehensive powers of management and disposal over their land, such as collecting land rent, exacting corvée labor, exercising judicial power, administrative management, military command, gifting land, inheriting land, and enfeoffing subordinate lords. Most importantly, this power was universally recognized by the entire society and protected by statutory or customary law; it was absolutely not something that could be easily arbitrarily deprived. Thus, we are able to sufficiently distinguish the feudal lords of Europe and Japan—who practically governed their hereditary fiefdoms and could enfeoff subordinate lords—from the military aristocracy of the Islamic world, who merely obtained land revenue rights or tax collection rights as compensation for military service.

Primary factor of production (首位生产要素): Refers to the one factor that holds the primary position among all factors of production. The specific concept is detailed in Chapter 6, Section 4.

Scarcity relations (稀缺性关系): Refers to the quantitative contrast among various factors of production based on supply and demand. The status of a deficient factor of production increases, while the status of a surplus factor of production decreases. Scarcity relations do not directly act upon productive forces, but they exert an impact on the mode of production. The most universally manifested scarcity relation in human history is the *land-labor ratio* (人地关系), namely the relative abundance or shortage of labor and land. When all factors of production can be fully converted into productive forces under existing technological levels, it can be considered that the factors of production are in a state of relative equilibrium—none is obviously in surplus, and none is obviously in shortage.

Commodity economy and Natural economy (商品经济和自然经济): No different from the definitions used in academia.

Slavery society (奴隶制社会): Any society where the phenomenon of exploitation exists, and where the direct exploitation of the exploited's labor power through bodily possession (人身占有) and forced labor dominates the forms of exploitation (in terms of proportion within economic activities), can be called a slavery society. A slavery society does not necessarily mean that the vast majority of the population are slaves; it is even possible that the majority of the population are not slaves.

Similarly, a society that exists with or even permits the institution of slavery cannot necessarily be termed a slavery society—such as the European countries that participated in the triangular trade. Furthermore, those who are directly exploited for their primary labor power to a certain extent might not necessarily be legally categorized as slaves in their identity; for instance, some free citizens were also subjected to mandatory forced labor by the state.

This revision helps resolve the situation where evaluations of slavery societies vary wildly across different regions of the world, we should point out that this new definition possesses a certain degree of rationality. The reason lies in the fact that, under the relatively backward conditions of productive forces in early states, economic exploitation was indeed the primary method for collecting and utilizing the *social surplus* (社会剩余), and the ultimate destination of this social surplus directly determines the evolutionary direction of the society. Therefore, if we ignore those

fruits of social labor production that cannot be effectively invested due to insufficient quantity and excessive dispersion, and instead focus our observation on the portion that could be executed as effective investment, then the definition of a "slavery society" does indeed reflect the true nature of early states.

Early state (早期国家): This concept is even more ambiguous. My view is that any state that has reached the form of a state, but is clearly in a *pre-classical* and *pre-feudal* state (the reason for emphasizing pre-feudal is that we have already seen some regions bypass the classical period and directly undergo *feudalization*), are collectively referred to as early states. I hold this view even if it means classifying some seemingly quite mature and complex states (such as Egypt during the New Kingdom period) as early states. Among the modes of exploitation existing in early states, slavery occupied the main body, and kinship (血缘) still held an important position in the state's political organization. The territory an early state could control was highly limited; its rule relied heavily on cities (city-states) as strongholds of domination, and it was heavily restricted by the natural environment.

Old nobility (旧贵族): This term carries the characteristics of communist nations; when I use it, it refers to the ruling class in early states. Evolving from clan chieftains, religious priests, and military leaders, they were historically viewed as possessing nobility of bloodline. The foundation of the old nobility's rule lay in their monopoly over the factors of production, with *knowledge* being particularly worthy of attention. The old nobility frequently possessed the identity of slave owners simultaneously.

Tribal group (部族): This concept is also quite ambiguous and it is basically impossible to reach any consensus. When I use it, it refers to the aggregate of all tribes (部落) within a certain geographical scope, where territorial identity has, to a certain extent, transcended blood relations, and a kind of common consciousness based on culture and language has emerged. A tribal group is generally still in the pre-state stage, but in some circumstances, it may be viewed as an early state, depending on internationally recognized standards.

Tribal confederacy (部族联盟): A political entity formed by tribal groups, encompassing a large number of tribes. The difference from a simple tribal alliance (部落联盟) lies in the fact that when I use the term tribal confederacy, I emphasize the stability of leadership succession; the ruler of a tribal confederacy is no longer produced through election by various tribes, but remains within one tribe for a long period and possesses a hereditary nature.

Community (社群): No different from the universal standard used in academia, though I may use it less strictly, sometimes appearing as an abbreviation for "social groups" (社会群体).

Civilization (文明): Although it is unlikely that everyone will reach a consensus on the definition of this concept, when I use it, there is no difference from international universal standards.

Country / State (国家): What is the precise definition of a state? Which regimes in history count as states? This is obviously another issue where consensus is impossible to achieve, but when I use it, there is no difference from international universal standards.

International universal standard (国际通用标准): When I refer to following "international universal standards" for certain concepts where consensus is difficult to reach, I mean the following principle. Assuming that for a particular element, the vast majority of scholars in the world believe it should belong to a certain set, then I will also consider that element to belong to this set. If the vast majority of scholars worldwide believe this element does not belong to the set, then I will also consider it not to belong to the set. For instance, regarding universally recognized states or civilizations, I will certainly view them as states or civilizations; however, for regimes universally acknowledged as not having met the standard of a state, or cultures not having met the standard of a civilization, I will likewise not view them as states or civilizations.

Bureaucratic state (官僚国家): Of course, one cannot say that any state possessing some form of bureaucratic system is a bureaucratic state; apart from rather primitive early states (早期国家), all states possess bureaucratic systems of varying complexity and divergent purposes. When I use the term "bureaucratic state," it absolutely indicates that the state's bureaucratic system plays a decisive role in the allocation of social resources (including the tangible, such as land and gold/silver, as well as the intangible, such as authority and information) and the determination of social status. In other words, the destiny of an individual or a family relies highly on their position within the bureaucracy, having no direct relationship with any other factors. It is not the case that a person attains a high position within the bureaucracy because they possess immense wealth, lofty social status, universally known prestige, or play a vital role in social production; rather, it is precisely because of their high position within the bureaucracy that all the aforementioned things can be easily acquired. The bureaucratic system of a normal state is constrained by various social forces, whereas the society of a bureaucratic state revolves around the bureaucratic system. Historically speaking, a powerful coalition of class interests (阶级利益共同体) is the primary force preventing the emergence of a bureaucratic state. Within a bureaucratic state, there does not exist a broadly recognized class alliance with unified core interests and formidable political power.

Governance-oriented bureaucratic system (治理型官僚制度): The most common bureaucratic system. Its primary purpose is to maintain the normal operation of the existing society. The governance nature of the bureaucratic system primarily reflects the state's capability to actually intervene in social life and effectively implement political decisions; it is mainly related to *infrastructural power* (基础性权力).

Predatory bureaucratic system (掠夺型官僚制度): I sometimes also refer to it as an extractive bureaucratic system (榨取型官僚制度); it is a type of bureaucratic system that may emerge during prolonged wars or military confrontations. Its primary goal is to efficiently and thoroughly extort the entire surplus of social production(社会生产剩余), even potentially committing acts tantamount to killing the goose that lays the golden eggs. Under certain circumstances, the massive wealth

extracted by this bureaucracy can be channeled into effective investments, but in the vast majority of cases, it fundamentally amounts to "extracting every single ounce of wealth only to squander it like dirt." The predatory nature of the bureaucratic system primarily reflects the state regime's capability to destroy social conventions and disregard the will of various social groups; it is mainly related to *despotic power* (专制性权力). States operating under a centrally commanded planned economy under Bolshevik rule in the 20th century can, in some circumstances, be viewed as predatory bureaucratic states, such as the Soviet Union in the 1930s.

Asphyxiating bureaucratic system (窒息型官僚制度): Or termed an oppressive bureaucratic system (压迫型官僚制度). Its primary purpose is to eliminate, regardless of cost, any factors that might cause a change in the social status quo. To achieve its purpose, this bureaucratic system may require a massive secret police apparatus and thus become a police state. However, soft methods can equally achieve the goal of obliterating culture; the **restoration-bureaucratic states** (复辟官僚国家) of the Ming and Qing dynasties essentially accomplished this, though it required the long-term domestication of the people. The asphyxiating nature of the bureaucratic system has a certain degree of requirement for both despotic power and infrastructural power.

Asphyxiating bureaucratic states generally exhibit relatively obvious predatory traits; the characteristic distinguishing them from predatory bureaucratic states is that the latter's purpose in plundering social wealth lies in making some sort of investment (including military purposes). Yet, in many cases, due to the deceptive nature of political propaganda, it is difficult for people to fully distinguish whether the fundamental purpose of certain government investments is precisely to "weaken the people" (弱民)—for example, the massive war-preparation movements in China and Albania during the latter half of the 20th century. When making the distinction, I basically judge by the results rather than the propaganda; unless the investments made by the government using the people's hard-earned wealth genuinely yield substantial returns, only then will I say this bureaucratic system is a predatory one.

Social surplus (社会剩余): When I use this term, it refers to the resources, wealth, time, or capabilities that remain in a society after the basic survival needs of all its members have been met.

Surplus of social production (社会生产剩余): Although some might question why I define two very similar concepts, there is indeed a distinction when I use them. When I use the concept of the *surplus of social production*, it refers to the surplus resources, wealth, time, or capabilities created by the labor of the entire society, beyond what is necessary to maintain the existing existence of the society. The cost of "maintaining the existing existence of the society" is obviously not lower than "meeting the basic survival needs of all members," because investments are required in various aspects such as administration, religion, circulation, and the military. Therefore, for the same society, unless it is exceedingly primitive, its *surplus of social production* is distinctly less than its *social surplus*.

Social efficiency (社会效率): Refers to the proportion of the *surplus of social production* that is utilized for *expanded reproduction* (扩大再生产), investment in science, education, literature, and

art, improvement of public services and welfare, advancement of humanitarian causes, and promotion of consumption.

Historical sequence (历史序列): Namely, the evolutionary sequence of human society. It sequentially comprises six historical stages: pre-state society, early state, classical society, feudal society, early modern society, and modern society. Not every nation is obliged to experience, or rather, has the fortune to experience all the stages up to the present. Likewise, many states in history cannot be categorized into any single one of these stages; however, we can absolutely use this historical sequence as a basis to position the regimes in ancient human history. For a country like China that completely detached from the historical sequence, I sometimes refer to it as a "derailed state" (脱轨国家), to indicate that it completely deviated from the normal developmental track of human society.

The Great Expansion (大扩张): Refers to the long-term process wherein, supported by crucial technologies represented by the use of iron tools, the capability of certain tribal groups (部族) to transform nature was massively enhanced, which in turn drastically expanded the scope of civilization through large-scale conquests, and rapidly developed societies possessing early-state levels in the conquered regions. This historical phenomenon was particularly prominent during the last millennium BCE, resulting in the formation of a batch of classical empires across the Eurasian continent. The Great Expansion created the necessary conditions for the formation of primary classical societies.

Another point worth noting is that precisely during the Great Expansion period, due to frequent wars and the relative scarcity of labor, the proportion of slaves in the total population of society was paradoxically larger than during the early state period; the stereotype people held in the past about a slavery society—that of "universally driving slaves into forced labor"—perhaps reflects more of the landscape of the Great Expansion period.

Classical characteristics (古典特征): Unprecedentedly (and perhaps never again) vast territorial expanse of the regime, formidable monarchical power, an army highly capable in warfare, a (relatively) mature bureaucratic apparatus, strong state capacity, unified weights and measures and legal codes, a (relatively) complex social structure, possessing a highly centralized large capital, simultaneous surges in the government's despotic power and infrastructural power, the use of a certain *lingua franca* (四方通语), prosperous urban life, active commodity economy, massive circulation of precious metals, open social ethos, relatively high status of women, highly inclusive social consciousness, coexistence of multiple schools of thought, state (monarch) sponsorship of large-scale academic institutions and individual scholars, prevalence of rationalism, emphasis on speculative thinking, abundant academic achievements in scientific and technological fields, the emergence of mega-engineering projects, excellent public services, and so on.

Typical classical state/empire (典型古典国家/帝国): Typical classical states are sometimes also written by me as genuine classical empires; the foundation of their establishment is the class transition (阶级交替) triggered during the process of land replacing labor as the primary factor of production, namely, the landlord class replacing the old nobility to become the new landlord class

(although at this time the natural economy does not yet dominate). This process not only generated a massive number of non-producing bureaucrats (脱产官僚) but also made it difficult for the ruling class (because it was undergoing transition) to form unified interest demands, which provided conditions for the formation of the classical bureaucratic system and the strengthening of monarchical absolutism. The state capacity of typical classical states was exceptionally formidable, which implies that their infrastructural power reached the highest level prior to the early modern period. Typical classical states include the Roman Empire during the Principate, the Western Han Empire, the Gupta Dynasty of India, the late Sasanian Empire, should include the Khmer Empire (though data is too scarce), and, in a certain sense, also includes Japan during the Insei (Cloistered Rule) period. Typical classical states will possess the vast majority of classical characteristics. Because of the robustness of their bureaucratic systems, I sometimes also refer to classical states as classical bureaucratic states.

Classical bureaucratic system (古典官僚体制): Namely, the bureaucratic system generally formed by classical bureaucratic states. The characteristics of the classical bureaucratic system lie in the complex backgrounds of its officials, the pluralism of ideologies, and the diversity of pathways to entering government service. Although the classical bureaucratic system may form a set of rules to maintain its own operation, the appointment, dismissal, promotion, and demotion of officials by the ruler based on personal needs and preferences remains the primary driving force behind the operation of the classical bureaucratic system. Compared to the bureaucratic systems of early modern and modern states, a characteristic of the classical bureaucratic system is that its official selection system is relatively rudimentary.

Primary classical state (原生古典国家): Classical states formed directly through the Great Expansion prior to the Common Era (BCE), rather than classical states formed in later periods under strong external influence; they existed exclusively in Greco-Roman, Persian, Indian, and Chinese civilizations. Based on observation, basically only primary classical states can manifest as typical classical states at a certain stage.

Formative classical state (形成期古典国家): Specifically refers to the large vassal kingdoms during the Warring States period of China. Because the process of the Great Expansion led by the Zhu Xia (various Chinese states) occurred relatively early, tribal groups and communities had already been largely eliminated in the latter half of the Great Expansion. Therefore, the germination of feudalism and the phenomenon of class transition in ancient China had already become highly evident by the late Warring States period, which became the prerequisite for the political reforms (变法) in the various vassal states, although China was not yet unified at this time.

Classical society (古典社会): The social formation possessed by typical classical states (典型古典国家) is classical society.

Classical period (古典时期): In a narrow sense, the classical period is the historical period during which typical classical states existed. In a broad sense, the classical period traces back to the formative period of typical classical states and extends forward to the collapse period of typical classical states. Under a looser definition, the period during which regimes exhibiting certain

classical characteristics appeared in relatively backward regions is also viewed as the classical period of that region.

Late Antiquity (古典时代晚期): In accordance with the definition by Western historians.

Classical empire (古典帝国): The classical empire in a narrow sense is the typical classical empire. The standard for a broad classical empire can be flexible, but it must at least ensure that no dislocation occurs in its historical developmental sequence. That is to say, once a certain regime is identified as a classical empire, the historical stage the local society was in before the establishment of this regime cannot be later than the classical period, and the historical stage the local society is in after the end of this regime cannot be earlier than the classical period. For example, before the Caliphate of Córdoba was established in Iberia, the Iberian Peninsula had already undergone *feudalization* (封建化); therefore, it cannot be viewed as a classical empire, but at best belongs to a kind of late-classical empire (晚期古典帝国). Similarly, the **restoration-bureaucratic empires** (复辟官僚帝国) do not belong to classical empires either, because northern China had already exhibited obvious feudalization characteristics during the Northern and Southern Dynasties. After the Songhai Empire was defeated by the Moroccans, the territory it ruled not only showed no obvious phenomenon of feudalization, but instead regressed to a state where a multitude of early states (早期国家) and even tribes stood in great numbers, and various folk religions remained prevalent; thus, it also cannot be viewed as a classical empire, but at best a highly developed early state due to its important position in the trade network. Likewise, the Xiongnu Empire cannot truly be viewed as a classical empire, because the Mongolian region never saw the emergence of a classical empire afterward, and feudalization did not become obvious until the late Ming Dynasty. I call this judgment principle the *principle of sequential invariance* (序位不变原则), which essentially insists on the following view: even if the so-called classical characteristics number in the thousands, the essence of the classical period is always a "transitional period" transitioning from an early state to a feudal society (封建社会). A universally recognized classical state should possess a certain number of classical characteristics. When I speak of classical empires, I generally refer to classical empires in the broad sense; otherwise, I will emphasize that I am speaking of genuine classical empires.

Chonggang Junfu / Towering Mountains (重冈俊阜): The literal meaning of this term in Chinese is high mountains. I use it to describe the thick filter people hold regarding the classical period and classical empires; the greatness of classical glory is excessively exaggerated, and too many unrealistic hopes are pinned upon it.

The zenith of classical empires or classical empires at their zenith (鼎盛时期的古典帝国或古典帝国的鼎盛时期): When I use this expression, it refers to the very, very literal historical period when a classical state is ostensibly at its most powerful. The only point I wish to remind the reader of is that there is a difference between the zenith of a classical empire and the historical period when classical society existed. Generally speaking, in the era when a classical empire appears most

powerful, the class transition (阶级过渡) has basically been completed, and the feudal mode of production (封建生产方式) occupies the mainstream; therefore, chronologically, it is later than classical society. The reason the empire has not yet declined due to feudalization is that the degree of land annexation is still relatively low, and the feudal manors of the natural economy (自然经济) have not yet universally appeared.

Early classical states/empires (早期古典国家/帝国): Refers to massive empires that already exhibited many classical characteristics before their societies had developed to the classical society stage. These include the Achaemenid Empire of Persia, the Parthian Empire, the Kushan Empire (dubious), and the Maurya Dynasty. The foundation of existence for such regimes lay in the central government's control over economic circulation as well as the autonomy of local tribal groups (部族) and communities (社群).

Imported classical states (输入型古典国家): Specifically refers to a series of regimes on the periphery of China. The societies of these regimes themselves had not developed to the classical society stage, but under the influence of China, they prematurely introduced China's bureaucratic system—especially the bureaucratic system of the Tang Dynasty's restoration period (唐代复辟时期)—thus exhibiting some classical characteristics. This type of state includes Goguryeo, Baekje, Silla and Unified Silla, Japan during the Asuka and Nara periods, the state of Balhae, and Nanzhao.

Classical nomadic empire (古典游牧帝国): Refers to the Xiongnu. The Xiongnu belonged to the spillover of the historical event of the Great Expansion (大扩张) occurring in the East Asian nomadic regions, and therefore possessed obvious classical characteristics.

Anomalous classical state (异常古典国家): Refers to the Goryeo regime on the Korean Peninsula. This state was indeed at the stage of classical society, but it erroneously introduced China's **restoration-bureaucratic system (复辟官僚制度)**.

Trade-based pseudo-classical states (贸易型伪古典国家): Refers to states whose societies were far from developing into the classical society stage, but because the region occupied a key position in international trade, they exhibited certain classical characteristics under external influence. These include Aksum, Srivijaya, the Khazar Khaganate, Mali, and Songhai. This type of state was extremely fragile and far from being a genuine classical state; once its trade status was lost or it collapsed due to military defeat, the local society would still lack signs of feudalization (封建化) for a very long time.

Land-labor pseudo-classical states (人地型伪古典国家): Refers to states whose societies were far from developing into the classical society stage, but because of a severe imbalance in the land-labor ratio (人地关系) and the highly obvious situation of limited land and a massive population,

the status of primary labor as the primary factor of production (首位生产要素) was challenged by land. Coupled with the emergence of refined production and the demand for complex cooperation, the state exhibited certain classical characteristics, especially an anomalously highly developed bureaucratic system. A representative example is the Third Dynasty of Ur. This type of state was fragile regardless of whether from institutional, environmental, or military aspects.

Late-classical states (晚期古典国家): Refers to states that, during the historical period when classical society had already ended and feudalization had become extremely obvious, still maintained partial classical characteristics, especially retaining the classical bureaucratic system (古典官僚体制). This type of state relied on its position in international trade and the government's control over circulation. The most typical late-classical state is the Byzantine Empire, and it should at least also include the Caliphate of Córdoba, and possibly the Pala Dynasty of Bangladesh.

Barbarians (蛮族): A collective term for the various ethnic groups that entered the core civilized regions on a massive scale during the late period of classical empires. This name does not mean that the barbarians were necessarily that backward compared to the classical empire; it merely emphasizes their identity as the "Other" (他者) relative to the classical empire. After the barbarians "entered the pass" (入关), the resulting growth in the level of productive forces gave them a massive demand to occupy land, thus making them the main force of feudalization.

Ru Guan / Entering the Pass (入关): This is a highly Sinicized expression, referring to the process by which a weak and small nation or faction conquers a large state through military victory.

Restoration-bureaucratic states (复辟官僚国家): Refers to a political state where, after classical society had completely ended and the feudal economic system (封建经济体制) had already emerged, due to the anomalously formidable bureaucratic system, the feudal landlord class (封建地主阶级) failed to obtain political ruling power and failed to further evolve into feudal lords (封建领主); the feudalization process was interrupted and subsequently regressed, causing the bureaucratic state to re-emerge. **Restoration-bureaucratic states** include China after the Sui and Tang dynasties, Vietnam after gaining independence from China, and the Joseon Dynasty in Korea.

The essence distinguishing **restoration-bureaucratic states** from late-classical states lies in the fact that the latter factually lacked the capability to cope with feudalization; they could only delay but not stop the impact of feudalization on the classical bureaucratic system, and still possessed a tendency towards dissolution. However, the **restoration-bureaucratic state** mastered complete political means to suppress the feudal landlord class, preventing the formation of large-scale landownership (大土地所有制), leaving the landlord class in a politically oppressed position by the bureaucratic state just like the ruled classes, and eliminating the threat of feudalization to the autocratic monarch and the bureaucratic regime. The despotic power (专制性权力) of the monarch anomalously surged precisely while the feudal economic system existed.

Restoration-bureaucratic system (复辟官僚制度): The bureaucratic system implemented by **restoration-bureaucratic states**, which underwent continuous changes and steady enhancement from the Tang through the Qing dynasties.

It is particularly noteworthy that many Western researchers consider the staggering waste of the *social surplus* (社会剩余) by the **restoration-bureaucratic system** to be a mere "blunder" (失策). In reality, however, the systematic destruction of the *social surplus*—ensuring that the *surplus of social production* (社会生产剩余) is barely generated at all—is precisely the very means by which the **restoration-bureaucratic system** maintains its own existence. This is because any effectively utilized *surplus of social production* has the potential to bring about changes that the **restoration-bureaucratic system** does not wish to see, which runs completely counter to its goal of "stability maintenance" (维稳).

Nevertheless, the bureaucratic system inherently possesses the attribute of over-expansion, and this is especially true for a **restoration-bureaucratic system** operating completely unchecked by any oversight. Therefore, the **restoration-bureaucratic system** cannot manage to destroy exactly as much *social surplus* as is produced. It invariably leads to a consequence where the social wealth it destroys becomes increasingly massive, to the point where maintaining basic social public services and reproduction becomes impossible. Once it senses a crisis, the **restoration-bureaucratic system** may attempt to save itself; yet, every self-rescue attempt only renders the system itself even more bloated and more destructive. The ultimate result is that the society enters a state of total collapse, which constitutes the declining phase of the so-called "**dynastic cycle**" (王朝周期律) in Chinese history.

Ebb tide (退潮): This is a description used personally by me. It refers to the phenomenon where a social stage within a certain historical sequence (历史序列)—primarily feudal society, of course—begins to have its political and economic systems disintegrate before it has spontaneously evolved and moved towards the next social stage. For example, the restoration of the bureaucratic state during the Sui and Tang dynasties, or the Islamic world and India under Western influence, can all be termed an "ebb tide of feudalization" (封建化退潮).

Pseudo-modernization (伪近(现)代化): Refers to the phenomenon where regions that have not completely experienced the stages of feudal society (封建社会) and early modern society (近世社会) introduce—solely under the influence of the Western world—the science, technology, organizations, institutions, and certain ideologies created by major developed countries since the High Middle Ages; however, their social existence generates a fierce resistance against these overly advanced imported goods. Pseudo-modernization is extremely prevalent worldwide.

Religious doctrine (宗教教义): Religious doctrine refers to the core beliefs, fundamental principles, and worldview of a religion. Put simply, it is the religion telling people what they should believe.

Religious law (宗教教法): Religious law consists of the laws and regulations formulated based on religious doctrine to standardize the behavior of believers; it is the concretization and application of doctrine. The function of religious law is to guide the behavioral norms of believers in their daily lives, encompassing religious rituals, ethics and morality, social relations, and other aspects. Put simply, it is the religion telling people what they should do.

Classical religion (古典宗教): Religions that responded to the various demands of classical society and possessed a relatively good capacity to adapt to various types of "classical states." Typified by Mahayana Buddhism, they may include Zoroastrianism, certain branches of early Christianity, and Khmerized Hinduism, and in a certain sense also encompass Han Dynasty Confucian scholasticism (汉代经学)—though I still maintain that Confucianism does not belong to the category of religion.

Classical religions might undergo adaptive changes in late-classical societies (晚期古典社会); their mystic tendencies and non-public rituals would increase, and they would further deify the monarch. The most typical example is Vajrayana Buddhism, and it should simultaneously include Eastern Orthodoxy.

Feudal religion / Feudalized religion (封建宗教 / 封建化宗教): Religions capable of adapting to the requirements of the historical process of feudalization (封建化), playing a massive role in maintaining basic circulation and technological investment during the early stages of feudal society. Compared to classical religions, the greatest characteristic of feudal religions lies in their penetration into the grassroots of society, being oriented towards the masses, simplifying methods of cultivation, emphasizing "salvation by faith" (因信得救), and possessing highly developed churches and religious orders (教团) that actively participate in social activities. Typical feudal religions include Catholicism, Japanese Buddhism, and Theravada Buddhism; they should also include Ethiopian Orthodoxy, the majority of sects within Hinduism and Islam, and, in a certain sense, Tibetan Buddhism. However, I want to emphasize that religion is not the essential characteristic of a certain society; religion possesses strong adaptability to changes in social existence, and one should not interpret it literally or superficially when making specific judgments.

The end of feudal religion (封建宗教的结束): As a region transitions from a feudal society into an early modern society (近世社会), secular state apparatuses and various social organizations rapidly expand their capabilities. Early modern society, objectively speaking, no longer needs feudal religion to play the vital role in social life that it did during the Middle Ages. Due to their inherent characteristics, religions' efficiency in assisting economic circulation and technological investment is surpassed by the various newly emerging institutions of the early modern era. The influence of religion on social ideology is also not conducive to the popularization of scientific concepts throughout the entire society. Therefore, during the period when a state transitions toward the early modern era, various forms of movements opposing feudal religion inevitably emerge—from the mildest religious reformations to the most violent activities, such as Oda Nobunaga's suppression of the *Ikki* (sectarian uprisings), which can all be witnessed in history. Religions that have undergone the baptism of early-modernization will no longer be as strictly managed organizationally (including both doctrine and law) as they were in the Middle Ages, and their

degree of participation in general social life significantly declines. Of course, as demonstrated by the European Reformation, new religious sects might be even stricter in their demands for moral precepts. The new sects that emerged in regions with the most developed commercial and industrial economies during the Reformation period—such as Protestant Christianity (基督新教)—can, in this sense, be termed an early modern religion.

Feudal holy war (封建圣战): Refers to wars instigated by feudal religions aimed at acquiring land and implementing the feudal system in the conquered regions, ultimately transforming the conquerors into the ruling class. The most typical feudal holy wars are the series of crusades launched by the Germans in the Baltic region starting from the High Middle Ages. Many *Jihads* launched by Islamic regimes also possessed the nature of a feudal holy war, but because the feudalization of the Islamic world was always incomplete, the results were not as typical. Not all hostile actions carrying the slogan of a religious holy war belong to feudal holy wars.

Classical lingua franca (古典通语): Sometimes taking the form of a classical universal script (古典通文). It refers to a spoken or written language officially recognized by a classical empire and widely used throughout the empire. During the feudal period after the end of the classical empire, it would still serve as the language used by the feudal religious church, until it was gradually replaced by feudal national languages.

Feudal national languages / Vernacular languages (封建民族语言): The languages of various nations formed during the feudal period; to be precise, the feudal national language is precisely one of the main characteristics that distinguish various nations in later times. The emergence of feudal national languages caused the classical *lingua franca* to essentially exit the historical stage. Examples include English, German, Amharic, Bengali, Thai, and so on.

The Landlord-Bureaucrat Compromise (地主-官僚妥协): Refers to a compromise reached between the barbarians (蛮族) and the Han Chinese landlord class in Northern China. The ethnic minority invaders abandoned the prospect of expropriating the land ownership of Han landlords in order to realize their own nation's feudalization (封建化); instead, they allowed chieftains at all levels to transform into bureaucrats at all levels, thus bureaucratizing their own nation. The underclass commoners among the ethnic minorities rapidly degenerated into miserable civilians under the bureaucratic system, indistinguishable from Han civilians, while the ethnic minority rulers became autocratic monarchs. Han Chinese landlords retained their land and continued to participate in state politics as bureaucrats, just as in the past. This process made land ownership, and even land property rights, in Northern China extremely stable under the impact of the great migrations of peoples; the bureaucratic system was not destroyed by feudalization at all, laying the foundation for the formation of the **restoration-bureaucratic state** (复辟官僚国家) and serving as the primary cause for the failure of China's feudalization. A similar phenomenon might also have occurred during the process of Islamic conquests.

Co-optation through official ranks and stipends (官位荣禄收买): Refers to the covert

weakening measures adopted by the government against the aristocratic great clans (门阀士族)—who were large-scale land owners—during the Sui and Tang dynasties, when China's **restoration-bureaucratic state** was newly established. The rulers conferred high positions within the bureaucratic system upon the aristocratic great clans, luring them into defending the authority of the bureaucratic system and concentrating their residence in Chang'an and Luoyang, thereby preventing them from becoming land-holding lords. The **restoration-bureaucratic state** effectively undermined the foundation upon which the aristocratic great clans were formed: namely, their control over the means of production (生产资料) and production itself, as well as their ability to bear military obligations based on land. This ostensible valuing, combined with overt and covert suppression, led to the decline and fall of the aristocratic great clans within three centuries; since then, China's landlord class has been unable to voice any noteworthy opinions in politics.

Bureaucratized landlords (官僚化地主): By this point, readers should be highly familiar with the nature of the group known as the Xiangshen (local scholar-elites 乡绅) in late imperial China. I list these concepts to emphasize that "the opposition between bureaucrats and landlords" and "the inextricable link between bureaucrats and landlords" were phenomena existing simultaneously within the **restoration-bureaucratic state**. The opposition refers to the bureaucratic system preventing landlords from seizing power: the normal evolutionary direction of landlords is to develop into feudal lords conducting political rule, but the bureaucratic system prevented this and incorporated the landlords into itself. This is an opposition in the evolutionary path, rather than a clear-cut dichotomy in the resultant outcome. The social status and rights of bureaucratized landlords derived primarily from the bureaucratic system, not from their control over the means of production. Their secondary economic identity was as landlords, while their primary political identity was as bureaucrats.

Resident feudal lords (在地领主): Feudal lords who reside on the land they own and participate in the production and management of the manor. Resident feudal lords possess relatively strong enthusiasm and capability for improving operational methods and raising agricultural levels.

The Han System (汉制): Refers to the political system—supported by China's unique classical bureaucratic system—formed through the *Genghua* (Reform) Movement during the reign of the seventh emperor, Emperor Wu of Han, Liu Che. Formed at the climax of the Han-Xiongnu Wars, the Han System carried a highly pronounced wartime flavor, exhibiting extreme mobilization capacity and predatory nature. The Han System's investments in military and technological fields were highly successful; within two centuries, it proved itself to be a terrifying instrument of war and a paragon of government intervention driving technological progress and popularization. Unlike typical classical bureaucratic systems, the classical bureaucratic system under the Han System endowed the entire bureaucratic apparatus with a unified ideology and a self-metabolizing system of official selection, along with standards for evaluation, promotion, and demotion. This led to the emergence of a scholar-official stratum (士大夫阶层) that shared common values, benefited through the bureaucratic system, and was highly bound to it. These characteristics of the Han System later became crucial reasons for the failure of China's feudalization and the reconstruction

of the **restoration-bureaucratic state**. The political systems of the Wei and Jin dynasties before the end of classical China can also be viewed as an evolution of the Han System during the early stage of feudalization.

The Tang System (唐制): Namely, the political system implemented during the Tang Dynasty; it serves as a milestone after the emergence of the **restoration-bureaucratic state**. Although the Tang System reserved political positions for the then-still-powerful aristocratic great clans and retained a massive number of feudalization characteristics, its ultimate goal was always to completely obliterate the threat feudalization posed to the bureaucratic state—and it indeed possessed the capability to achieve this goal. Because the Tang System was able to maintain strong military capabilities in the short term and, unexpectedly, could be utilized in the manner of the classical era and the period preceding it, it caused immense destruction to China's periphery.

The Song System (宋制): Namely, the political system implemented during the Song Dynasty; it is the mark of complete maturity for the **restoration-bureaucratic state**. The Song System utterly eliminated the threat posed by the feudal landlord class to the **restoration-bureaucratic system**; it no longer left any place for the aristocratic stratum within China's political structure, indiscriminately placing the entire society under the rule of the **restoration-bureaucratic state**. However, the Song System still possessed the flexibility to release feudal elements in moments of critical peril to preserve itself. The Song System belongs to a highly specialized political system evolved from the processes of Chinese society; it is almost impossible for other nations to emulate it, and therefore it poses less of a threat externally.

Late Imperial China (中华帝国晚期): In the Chinese context, this precisely refers to the Ming and Qing dynasties.

Our timeline (本位面): Refers to the real world in which we currently live.

Chaotic Era (乱纪元): Refers to historical periods characterized by the frequent occurrence of unpredictable, large-scale catastrophic events.

Political efficiency (政治效率): Refers to the capability and efficiency of a political system (e.g., a state, government, political party, etc.) in achieving its established goals or satisfying social needs. It measures the political system's ability to achieve maximum results with minimal resource input.

Social being / Social existence (社会存在): In accordance with the views of Marx and Engels, when I use this term, it refers to the sum total of the material living conditions of society that people are situated in during a certain historical period, particularly their *mode of production* (生产方式), *relations of production* (生产关系), and the social structure determined by these relations.

Social consciousness (社会意识): In accordance with the views of Marx and Engels, when I use this term, it refers to the sum total of various ideologies, viewpoints, emotions, psychology, and the various forms expressing these contents that arise on the basis of a certain *social being*. Sometimes I also refer to it as social concepts (社会观念).

Social foundation (社会基础): When I use this term, it refers to the sum total of the various elements and conditions necessary to constitute the normal operation and stable existence of a society.

Minzhi / The people's intellectual and emotional capacity (民智): Knowledge at the rational level, as well as the ability to acquire, understand, and master knowledge; coupled with emotions at the perceptual level, as well as the ability to generate, perceive, and express emotions.

Minli / The people's physical capacity and labor (民力): Primarily refers to primary labor power represented by physical labor. However, in actual usage, it goes beyond this; for example, Chinese rulers driving the common people into war also belongs to a part of extracting "Minli," even though war obviously does not constitute productive labor.

Productive forces (生产力): In accordance with the views of Marx and Engels, when I use this term, it refers to the capability of a specific society to transform nature and acquire material resources during the production process.

Relations of production (生产关系): In accordance with the views of Marx and Engels, when I use this term, it refers to the mutual relations formed by people during the production process; it is the position people occupy and the form of their mutual connections in the process of producing, distributing, exchanging, and consuming material resources.

Economic base (经济基础): In accordance with the views of Marx and Engels, when I use this term, it refers to the sum total of the dominant *relations of production* in a certain society, which constitutes the foundation of the social formation.

Superstructure (上层建筑): In accordance with the views of Marx and Engels, when I use this term, it refers to the sum total of various political, legal, ideological, and cultural institutions established upon a certain *economic base* and serving to maintain that *economic base*.

Labor productivity (劳动生产率): An important indicator for measuring economic efficiency, reflecting the quantity of output generated per unit of labor input. Simply put, it measures how much value is created or how many products are produced by a worker within a unit of time.

Infrastructural power (基础性权力): In accordance with the views of Michael Mann, this refers to the capacity of the state to penetrate and coordinate the various spheres of society through social infrastructure (such as laws, administrative agencies, education systems, transportation networks, communication systems, etc.). Infrastructural power emphasizes institutionalized, cooperative, and long-term impact. In Imperial China, those who exercised infrastructural power were primarily the general administrative bureaucrats mentioned in Chapter 9, Section 7. Because exercising infrastructural power makes it easy for bureaucrats to transform into the ruling class by appropriating the means of production, for the supreme ruler, it is best if these general administrative bureaucrats are rotating officials (*Liuguan* / 流官).

Despotic power (专制性权力): In accordance with the views of Michael Mann, this refers to the capacity of state rulers to arbitrarily intervene in social life without being constrained by institutional checks. Despotic power emphasizes arbitrariness, repressiveness, and short-term impact. In Imperial China, those who exercised despotic power were primarily the highly specialized bureaucrats mentioned in Chapter 9, Section 7, whose purpose was to expand and safeguard the monarch's interests. They were highly dependent on the supreme ruler and could not easily transform into the ruling class; for the supreme ruler, it is best if these servile retainers (奴才) possess a hereditary nature (世袭性).

Middle Ages and Chūsei (中世纪和中世): When I use the concepts of the "Middle Ages" spoken of by Europeans, the "*Chūsei*" spoken of by the Japanese, and "feudal society" (封建社会), I make no distinction among them; they refer to the exact same thing. By European standards, it roughly refers to the timeframe defined by the social formation between 500 CE and 1500 CE. Sometimes this concept is also expressed as the "medieval period" (中古).

Early Middle Ages or Early Feudal Period (中世纪早期或封建早期): Namely, the timeframe defined by the social formation of Western Europe between 500 CE and 1000 CE.

High Middle Ages or High Feudal Period (中世纪盛期或封建盛期): Namely, the timeframe defined by the social formation of Western Europe between 1000 CE and 1300 CE. The High Middle Ages is a historical period of comprehensive social resurgence; during this stage, major social indicators such as population and economic scale surpassed the levels of the classical period (古典时期).

Late Middle Ages or Late Feudal Period (中世纪晚期或封建晚期): Namely, the timeframe defined by the social formation of Western Europe between 1300 CE and 1500 CE.

The Early modern period (近世/近代): Namely, the "early modern era." The historical period from the collapse of feudal society to the formation of modern society.

Early modern society (近世社会): A social formation transitioning from a feudal society to a capitalist society (modern society). Its characteristics include the formation of nation-states, absolutist rule, the frequent launching of foreign wars with persistently high military expenditures, a surge in economic circulation, intellectual liberation and the Scientific Revolution, the disintegration of the hierarchical system (等级制度), the rise of the civic class (市民阶层), and so on. Because Western scholars have long studied their own early modern history thousands of times over, it is impossible for me to add anything new. The only point I wish to emphasize is that early modern society possesses characteristics of class transition (阶级过渡) similar to the classical period: capital replaces land as the *primary factor of production* (首位生产要素), and the bourgeoisie is in the process of replacing the *feudal landlord class* (封建地主阶级) to become the

ruling class of the state. The relative balance of power among various social classes and the inconsistency of their demands became the social foundation upon which the absolute monarchy of the early modern state could be established and maintained for a certain period. Although it will inevitably cause controversy, I insist on classifying Edo-period Japan as an early modern state. Only a very small number of countries in the world have experienced early modern society, and having experienced early modern society can almost be viewed as a prerequisite for becoming a developed country today (excluding pocket states; simultaneously, for former colonies that inherited the religious, cultural, and linguistic characteristics of their metropolises, their historical processes prior to independence are viewed as identical to those of their metropolises, because these former colonies essentially replicated the social structures of the metropolises).

Absolute monarchy (绝对君主制): Specifically refers to the political system wherein, under the condition of a class transition within the ruling class of an early modern society, the monarch is constrained neither by the feudal system nor by the state apparatus of the bourgeoisie, resulting in a surge of the monarch's *despotic power* (专制性权力). When I use this term, I strictly confine it to early modern monarchical states, represented by Bourbon France. Any political system where the society has not reached the early modern stage, yet the monarch possesses immense *despotic power*, cannot be viewed as an absolute monarchy—whether it be the Ottoman Empire, the Ming and Qing empires, the Inca Empire, or modern-day Brunei and Saudi Arabia.

Absolutist state (绝对主义国家): No different from the universally accepted definition in academia.

Early modern state (近世国家): States established on the foundation of early modern society. Monarchical early modern states will generally develop characteristics of an absolute monarchy at a certain stage. A few early modern states appear to have become republics or figurehead monarchies (i.e., constitutional monarchies) very early on; however, one should note that the indigenous territories of these states are very small, and practically no relatively independent developmental process existed. They originally ought to have been a part of the political balance within a larger early modern regime—namely, the regions with the most developed commercial and industrial economies—but ultimately became independent due to Europe's complex political shifts. The Netherlands is precisely such a case.

Capitalism (资本主义): I personally have never been abroad and have never seen it, and the social stage in which this economic system emerged is simply too distant from China; therefore, I cannot make any evaluation. Just following the universally recognized standards in academia will suffice.

Capitalist society (资本主义社会): Ditto. It is difficult for me to comprehend personally; it should be a society that implements a capitalist economic system where the bourgeoisie holds the ruling position. What I want to say is that capitalist societies, in the vast majority of regions where they operate relatively well, are built upon the foundation of the local area having experienced an early modern society, or else they were colonies established after the Age of Discovery. Obviously, it is absolutely not the case that a society at just any random developmental stage can transform into a capitalist society by forcibly transplanting a capitalist economic system. Currently, I can only observe extremely rare exceptions like the Republic of Korea. Considering the connection between

the historical processes of China and the Korean Peninsula, I believe South Korea's success holds immense value for China.

Capitalist state (资本主义国家): Ditto. It is difficult for me to comprehend personally. A state established upon a capitalist society. As far as I know, the degree of democracy in capitalist states is the best in history, which perhaps precisely reflects the significance of the social restructuring that has occurred since the High Middle Ages. However, whether modern society and capitalist society can truly be equated seems to have no conclusive verdict.

Modern society and Modern state (现代社会和现代国家): Difficult to evaluate; it is hard for me to know exactly what these two concepts look like. At present, it seems capitalist society is synonymous with modern society, and a modern state is a capitalist state.

Modernity (现代性): I basically agree that modernity is a form of social development and culture opposed to traditional society, with its core lying in the belief in rationality, science, progress, and universality. It originated from the Enlightenment in Europe and gradually expanded globally in the 19th and 20th centuries; however, outside of developed nations, the acceptance of modernity by societies in other places is extremely limited.

Postmodernity (后现代性): Allegedly, postmodernity is a reflection upon and critique of modernity, arguing that the rationality, science, progress, and universality pursued by modernity are all illusory; it emphasizes plurality, difference, relativity, and deconstruction. However, since our society is still an unimaginably long way from the modern era, I am simply unable to accurately understand what developed countries consider to be postmodernity.

Definition of the various parts of Europe (欧洲各个部分的界定): As far as I know, there has never been a unified standard for dividing Western Europe, Northern Europe, Eastern Europe, Southern Europe, and Central Europe; this is even more difficult for a Chinese person like myself who has never been abroad. When I speak of "Western Europe" during the early stage of

feudalization (封建化), I generally refer to the Europe of the Western Roman Empire, the core of which is England, France, Northern Italy, the Low Countries, and certain regions of western Germany. But why do I sometimes adopt the term "the western part of Europe"? The reason is that history is inherently dynamically changing. A simplest example is that the concept of Germany expanded drastically eastward during the High Middle Ages. If it is quite reasonable to say "Germany is a Western European country" in the 10th century CE, the Holy Roman Empire of 1300 CE looks, by all accounts, more like a Central European state. Therefore, when I speak of Western Europe or the western part of Europe, I actually intend to refer to the core region of feudal Europe. This concept indeed expanded over time, while Eastern Europe and Northern Europe are situated in the peripheral regions defined by their corresponding directional terms.

East Asia (东亚): The scope covered by the territories of the five present-day countries: China, North Korea, South Korea, Vietnam, and Japan. Because Xinjiang and Tibet belong to China, I also consider them to be in the East Asian region. However, when referring to Xinjiang, I view it as belonging to "Inner Asia" (亚洲内陆), and when referring to Tibet, I will simply say it belongs to the main body of the Qinghai-Tibet Plateau.

Handi / China Proper (汉地): Namely, the lands where the Han ethnic group constitutes the dominant majority. It basically corresponds to the scope defined by the 18 provinces during the Qing Dynasty, including Zhili, but excluding the present-day Northeast China region where the Han currently constitute the vast majority. When describing earlier time periods, regions like Yunnan and Guizhou might not be counted within *Handi*; however, readers will understand upon a moment's thought, and it does not affect comprehension.

Zhongyuan / The Central Plains (中原): A Chinese cultural-geographical concept, centered on Henan Province and radiating toward surrounding vast regions such as Guanzhong, Jiangnan, Huaisi, and Heshuo, viewed as the cradle of the Chinese nation and the center of civilization.

Northeast Asia (东北亚): The scope covered by Japan, North Korea, South Korea, Northeast China, and the Russian Far East, which should be completely consistent with the universally recognized Northeast Asia.

Korea (朝鲜): When I mention Korea or Koreans, I basically refer to the entire peninsula or the inhabitants of the entire peninsula. If I am referring to the North Korean regime (北朝鲜政权), it should be very easy to judge based on the context. (注：英文中 *Korea* 天然指代历史上的整个半岛，而 *North Korea* 指代朝鲜政权，这里完美契合你的语境。)

Eurasian Steppe (欧亚大草原): No different from the definition used in academia.

Southeast Asia (东南亚): No different from the general classification. However, sometimes when I mention Southeast Asia, I might be referring to Southeast Asia excluding the parts east of the Wallace Line (华莱士线) and the entire Philippines.

South Asia (南亚): When I speak of South Asia, it refers to the scope covered by the territories of the seven countries: India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Bhutan, Sri Lanka, and the Maldives, and does not include Afghanistan.

Central Asia (中亚): When I speak of Central Asia, it refers to the six countries: Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Turkmenistan, Uzbekistan, and Afghanistan. I count Afghanistan as Central Asia, but I do not count Xinjiang as Central Asia.

The Middle East (中东): When I speak of the Middle East, it refers to the region bounded by the Mediterranean Sea, the Black Sea, the Greater Caucasus Mountains, the Caspian Sea, and the Indian Ocean, and enclosed within Turkey, Cyprus, Egypt, and Iran—naturally including the territories of these four countries as well.

The Near East (近东): When I use the concept of the Near East, it basically refers to the Middle East prior to the Islamic conquests, but the specific regions it includes are smaller: it excludes the central and southern parts of the Arabian Peninsula that do not border the Red Sea, as well as the

Iranian Plateau with the exception of its southwestern part (the southwestern part of Iran is included in the Near East because of the presence of the Elamite civilization / 埃兰文明).

中文原文：

30, 关于概念使用和定义的问题

在这个十几万字大章的最后，因为本人不可避免地会引入一些自己提出的概念，一些用词也不一定非常准确，所以在这里给出我在使用历史名词时采用的定义标准，供读者参考和批评。

阶级与阶层：阶级和阶层虽然在用法上已经被长期混淆，但是我认为仍然应该进行最起码的区分努力。我不赞成把国家政府或者官僚体制视为一个阶级，因为在我看来“阶级”这个词应该表明其描述对象与某种特定的生产方式相关联，也就是说当一类人被划为一个阶级的时候，这个集合的特征是其“元素”普遍采用某种特定的生产方式直接创造生产力。正是因为阶级能够以各种方式参与劳动生产，他们才能够从技术，文化，艺术和生产关系等各个角度对人类文明产生影响。这其实反映了马克思主义的一贯观点，历史发展是由各个阶级的运动决定的。我认为马恩原有理论的完成度而言，我们没有必要否认它，而是应该尽可能的去伪存真，使之能够自治且普适。

与阶级不同，国家政府或者官僚体制是脱产的，你确实可以说他在生产关系中具有某种位置，甚至承担了重要的社会功能，但是他的确不和某种特定的生产方式挂钩。这样我们就把官僚体制置于阶级叙事中的一个特殊位置，这种分辨是非常有利的。同样的，你可以看到知识分子这个集合的元素也不一定采用一种共同的生产方式，所以我们也应该将其称为知识分子阶层，而不是阶级。阶级和阶层的一个显著的区别在于，阶级会随着时代发展产生和淘汰，这本质上是由生产方式的产生和淘汰所决定的。而承担特定社会功能的阶层可能会延续非常长的时间，这是因为社会功能不一定会随着阶级运动带来的社会形态变动而消失。苏美尔时期就有官僚阶层，就有知识分子阶层，今天这个世界也有，但是已经相隔五千年了。

我们还应该注意到的是，阶层的一个子集很有可能可以被划为阶级，因为阶层的整体未必具有一个一致的生产方式，但是对其一部分未必。例如说早期国家所存在的祭司，抛开其宗教和行政性质来说，祭司作为知识分子的一部将作为劳动力组成部分的知识投入到农业生产和工程建设当中，他们确实以特定的生产方式创造了生产力。因此把祭司叫做祭司阶级在很大程度上是被允许的，这也就是为什么人们通常谈到早期国家的统治阶级的时候，会把祭司算作其中一员。

最后，我认为应当把商人，特别是不负责生产商品，只负责流通环节的行商视为阶层而不是阶级。读者在正文中能看到，这种划分对我们解释“贸易型伪古典国家”和“晚期古典国家”是有利的。而且我们也应当指出，虽然商人作为一个必要的社会功能不可或缺，但是其的确无法在一个大尺度系统中作为主要文化的创造者。只有像粟特城邦这种体量比较小，又因为处在主要贸易路线中，贸易通量极大时的社会，商业文化才能占到主导。

封建经济制度：指以个体小生产为主要生产模式，租佃制为主要经营方式，或者左一些地说为主要剥削方式（以上也即“封建生产方式”），自然经济色彩明显的经济制度。经济生产的基本单位一般是庄园。地租的形式随着封建经济的发展存在变化，总体来说是从实物到货币。在各级封建地主通过取得政治统治地位成为封建领主之后，封建社会应该呈现出大土地所有权的特征，即土地经过各种形式的兼并集中程度达到高水平。农奴制在不同程度上存在，因具体环境的不同农民对于领主的依附程度强弱存在差异，但无论如何弱于早期的奴隶制。城市经济在中世纪早期属于庄园的附属物，但是在中世纪盛期已经取得了一定独立性，长途商业活动，货币经济和自治权发展明显。

庄园经济：与学界通用的定义无异。

封建政治制度：基于封建经济制度，在封建地主阶级取得政治统治权之后（自发）组织起的政治体制，以中世纪盛期的英、法、德地区为标准。最大的特征即层级明显的封建权力等级制度，存在一系列权利和义务，尤其是土地所有权和效忠关系具有世袭性。封建制度中存在以作为中下层统治阶级的军事贵族，翻译为骑士或者武士，其社会地位维持依赖于军事服役。

要注意的是，以上两个概念是以封建盛期作为标准，全世界各地的封建社会短则四五百年，长则上千年，显然存在一个发展的过程。例如早在北京篇的时候就已经提过，从财产继承制度的情况来看，整个封建时期就存在着由析产制向长子继承制的变化。因此，在坚持原则的前提下，实际判断还要结合具体情况分析。从较为宽松的角度来说，在土地作为首位生产要素的条件下，凡地主阶级作为统治阶级出现，并且在政治上完全取得主导权，能够贯彻其意志的社会皆属于封建社会。

准封建制度：具有一定程度的封建政治制度特征但是没有达到封建政治制度标准的政治制度，以伊斯兰世界的伊克塔制度及其各种本地变形为例。

封建社会：实行封建经济制度和封建政治制度的社会。之所以只用提经济和政治两个方面，无非是因为这两个方面只要实现了，其余的因素都会自发地适应或者产生。

封建特征：封建社会所具有的经济、政治、军事、宗教和文化各个领域的特征。主要内容就是在封建经济制度和封建政治制度中。

封建时期：封建社会存在的历史时期。

封建主义：虽然“主义”这个词在中国非常偏向于意识形态和经济关系。但是当我提到封建主义的时候指的是封建社会所有特征的集合，包括经济制度，政治制度，军役制度，盛行宗教，社会观念等等。

封建化：这个概念被我用来形容封建社会演变的整个过程，它强调一种变化的趋势。

封建地主阶级：封建经济制度中的统治阶级，是生产资料的控制者和社会生产的主导者。但是我在使用封建地主阶级这个概念时仅仅指的是其在政治上未能取得统治权的情况，例如在复辟官僚时期的中国。

封建领主：在政治上取得统治权的封建地主阶级，我主要将这个概念用在封建的欧洲和日本。

封建时期的土地所有权：无论如何，即使是在西欧和日本那样典型的封建社会，封建领主所拥有的“土地所有权”都绝不可能与现在意义上的土地所有权完全相同，前现代社会的法律概念也不可能与现代社会一样清楚和完善。毕竟封建社会和现代社会之间还隔了近世这样一个完整的历史阶段，如今人类社会的复杂程度就完全不是之前任何一个历史时期能够想象的。归根到底，中世纪封建领主对于土地的所有权还是一种附带义务的用益权

（Usufruct）。如果将其理解成为绝对的支配权，那就连层层分封这种政治现象都难以解释了。当我们说“封建领主取得土地所有权”这件事的时候，其实指的还是封建领主具有对自己土地有非常全面的管理和处分的权力，比如收取地租，征收劳役，行使司法权，行政管理，军事指挥，赠予土地，继承土地和分封下级领主等。而且尤其重要的是，这种权力得到了全社会的普遍认可，成文法或习惯法的保护，绝不是可以被轻易剥夺的。这样我们就足以把实际治理自己世袭领地，并且可以分封下级领主的欧洲和日本的封建领主与仅仅获得土地收益权或者征税权作为军事服役报酬的伊斯兰世界军事贵族相区分。

首位生产要素：即所有生产要素中具有首要地位的一个，具体概念在第六章第四节。

稀缺性关系：指的是各生产要素基于供求关系在数量上的多寡对比，不足的生产要素地位增加，有余的生产要素地位下降。稀缺性关系不直接作用于生产力，但是会对生产方式产生影响。在人类历史中表现最普遍的稀缺性关系是人地关系，即劳动力和土地的相对多寡。当各生产要素在现有技术水平下均可充分转化为生产力时，可以认为各生产要素处于相对平衡状态，没有谁是明显富余的，也没有谁是明显短缺的。

商品经济和自然经济：跟学界使用的定义没有区别。

奴隶制社会：奴隶制社会：凡是该社会中存在剥削现象，并且在剥削形式中以人身占有和强迫劳动直接剥削被剥削者劳动力的方式占主导（对经济活动中的比例而言）的社会，都可以称为奴隶制社会。奴隶制社会不一定绝大多数人口都是奴隶，甚至可能大部分人口都不是奴隶。同样的，存在甚至允许奴隶制度的社会，也不一定能够被称为奴隶制社会，比如参

与三角贸易的欧洲国家。甚至于被某种程度上直接剥削初级劳动力的人，也不一定能在身份上被划为奴隶，例如一些自由民也会被国家要求强制服役。

这种修正有助于解决奴隶制社会在世界各地评价千差万别的状态，我们指出这个新定义确实有一定合理性。原因在于，在早期国家相对落后的生产力条件下，经济剥削确实是收集并利用社会剩余的主要方式，而社会剩余的去向将直接决定社会的演化方向。因此如果我们忽略那些因为数量不足且过于分散而无法被有效投资的社会劳动生产成果，重点观察可能被执行有效投资的部分，那么奴隶制社会这个定义确实反映了早期国家的本色。

早期国家：这个概念更加模糊，我的观点是，凡是能够达到国家形态，但是又显然处于前古典和前封建状态（之所以强调前封建，是因为我们已经看到一些地区可以不经由古典时期直接封建化）的国家统统都称为早期国家。哪怕这样会把一些看起来已经相当成熟和复杂的国家都归为早期国家（比如新王国时期的埃及）也在所不惜。早期国家存在的剥削方式中奴隶制占了主体，血缘仍然在国家政治组织中占有重要地位。早期国家能够控制的地区十分有限，其统治严重依赖于城市（城邦）作为统治据点，受自然环境限制大。

旧贵族：这个说法具有共产主义国家的特色，我在使用的时候是指早期国家中的统治阶级。他们由氏族首领，宗教祭司和军事领袖演变而来，在当年被视为具有血统上的尊贵性。旧贵族统治的基础在于其对于生产要素的垄断，尤其值得注意的是知识。旧贵族经常同时具有奴隶主的身份。

部族：这个概念也相当模糊而且基本不太可能有什么共识。我在使用的时候指的是一定地域范围内所有部落的集合体，地域认同在一定程度上超越了血缘关系，某种基于文化和语言的共同意识产生了。部族一般来说还处于前国家阶段，但也可能在一些情况下被视为早期国家，这取决于世界公认的标准。

部族联盟：由部族形成的政治实体，包含数目众多的部落。与部落联盟不同的地方在于，我在使用部族联盟时强调了首领继承的稳定性，部族联盟的统治者不再是各个部落推举产生，而是长期处于一个部落并且具有世袭性质。

社群（Community）：与学界的通用标准无异，但是我在使用的时候可能没有那么严格，有的时候会作为“社会群体”的简称出现。

文明（Civilization）：虽然这个概念的定义不太可能让每个人都达成一致，但我在使用的时候与国际通用标准没有区别。

国家（Country）：国家的精确定义是什么？历史上哪些政权算国家？这显然又是一个不可能取得一致的问题，但我在使用的时候与国际通用标准没有区别。

国际通用标准：我在这里对于一些难以达成共识的概念所说的遵循“国际通用标准”是指这样一种原则。假设对于某一个元素，世界上绝大多数学者都认为他应该属于某一个集合，那么我也会认为该元素属于这个集合。如果世界上绝大多数学者都认为这个元素不属于该集

合，那么我也会认为该元素不属于该集合。比如说对于公认的国家或者文明我肯定也会把他们视为国家或者文明，但是公认没有达到国家标准的政权或者没有达到文明标准的文化，我也不将其视为国家和文明。

官僚国家：当然不能说存在某种官僚制度的国家都是官僚国家，除了相当原始的早期国家以外，所有国家都拥有或简单或复杂，目的不一的官僚制度。当我说“官僚国家”这个词的时候，指的一定是这个国家的官僚制度对于分配社会资源（包括看得见摸得到的，比如土地和金银，也包括看不见摸不着的，比如权限和信息）和确定社会地位具有决定性的作用。换言之，个人或家族的命运高度依赖于其在官僚体制中的位置，与其他因素都没有什么直接关系。不是因为一个人拥有巨大的财富，崇高的社会地位，妇孺皆知的名望，对社会生产起到重要作用而在官僚体制中获得高位，而是因为官僚体制中的高位所以前面所有东西都可以轻易取得。一般国家的官僚体制受多种社会力量的制约，而官僚国家的社会围绕官僚体制运转。从历史上看，强有力的阶级利益共同体是阻止官僚国家出现的主要力量。在官僚国家内部，不存在一个具有广泛认同的，核心利益一致的，具有强大政治力量的阶级联盟。

治理型官僚制度：最普通的官僚制度。它的主要目的是维持现有社会的正常运行。官僚制度的治理性主要反映的是国家实际干预社会生活，有效实施政治决策的能力，它主要与基础性权力有关。

掠夺型官僚制度：我有的时候也称为榨取型官僚制度，它是一种可能出现在长期战争或军事对抗中的官僚制度。它的主要目标是高效彻底地搜刮整个社会生产剩余，甚至可能做出杀鸡取卵的事情。在某些情况下这种官僚体制榨取出的巨额财富能够进行有效投资，但是在绝大多数情况下基本上都是“取之尽锱铢，用之如泥沙”。官僚制度的掠夺性主要反映的是国家政权破坏社会惯例，无视各个社会团体意愿的能力，它主要与专制性权力有关。20世纪布尔什维克统治下采取中央指令性计划经济的国家在一些情况下就可以被视为掠夺型官僚国家，例如30年代的苏联。

窒息型官僚制度：或者称作压迫型官僚制度。它的主要目的是不计成本地消灭任何可能造成社会现状发生改变的因素。这种官僚制度为了实现其目的可能需要庞大的特务机构，并且成为警察国家。然而软性手段同样可以达成消灭文化的目的，明清时期的复辟官僚国家基本上就做到了，只不过这需要对人进行长期的驯化。官僚制度的窒息性对于专制性权利和基础性权利都有一定程度的要求。

窒息型的官僚国家一般都会有比较明显的掠夺性，使其与掠夺型官僚国家相区分的特征是后者掠夺社会财富的目的在于进行某种投资（包括军事目的）。但是很多时候因为政治宣传的欺骗性，人们难以完全分清有些政府投资的根本目的是不是就在于“弱民”，例如20世纪后半叶中国和阿尔巴尼亚的大规模战备运动。我在做区分的时候基本上都是论结果不论宣传，除非政府用民脂民膏进行的投资真的有可观的回报，我才说这种官僚制度是掠夺型的。

社会剩余：我在使用时指的是一个社会在满足了所有成员的基本生存需求之后，所剩余的资源、财富、时间或能力。

社会生产剩余：虽然可能会有人怀疑我为什么要定义两个非常相似的概念，但是我在使用它们时确实是有分别的。我在使用社会生产剩余这个概念时指的是整个社会的劳动所创造出的除必要的用于维持原有社会存在以外多余出来的资源、财富、时间或能力。“维持原有社会存在”的成本显然不低于“满足所有成员的基本生存需求”，因为行政、宗教、流通和军事诸多方面都需要投入。所以对于同一个社会来说，除非过于原始，它的社会生产剩余都明显少于社会剩余。

社会效率：指的是社会生产剩余被用于扩大再生产，进行科教文艺投资，完善公共服务和福利，推进人道主义事业，促进消费的比例。

历史序列：即人类社会演进的顺序。依次是前国家社会，早期国家，古典社会，封建社会，近世社会和现代社会六个历史阶段。不是每一个民族都有必要经历，或者说有运气经历迄今为止全部阶段。同样历史上很多国家并没有办法划归到其中任何一个阶段，不过我们完全可以以这个历史序列为依据对人类古代史上的政权进行定位。像中国这样完全脱离历史序列的国家，我在有的时候称其为“脱轨国家”，以示其完全偏离了人类社会正常发展的轨道。

大扩张：指在以铁器使用为代表的重要技术支持下，一些族群改造自然的能力大幅增强，进而通过大范围的征服剧烈扩张了文明的范围，并且在被征服地区迅速发展出具有早期国家水平的社会的长期过程。这一历史现象在公元最后一个千年尤为显著，其结果是在欧亚大陆形成了一批古典帝国。大扩张为原生的古典社会形成创造了必要条件。

还有一点值得注意的是，正是在大扩张时期，因为频繁的战争和劳动力的相对稀缺，奴隶占社会总人口的比例反而比早期国家时期要大，过去人们对于奴隶制社会那种“普遍驱使奴隶进行强迫劳动”的刻板印象或许更多反映的是大扩张时期的面貌。

古典特征：政权疆域空前（甚至是绝后）辽阔，君主权力强大，军队能征善战，官僚机构（相对）成熟，国家能力强，统一的度量衡和法典，社会结构（相对）复杂，具有一个集权的大首都，政府专制性权力和基础性权力同时高涨，使用某种四方通语，城市生活繁荣，商品经济活跃，贵金属大量流通，社会风气开放，女性地位较高，社会意识包容性强，多种学派共存，国家（君主）赞助大型学术机构和学者个人，理性主义流行，重视思辨，科学和技术领域学术成果多，大型工程涌现，公共服务良好等等

典型古典国家（帝国）：典型古典国家有的时候我也写作真正的古典帝国，其建立的基础是土地取代劳动力成为首位生产要素过程中引起的阶级交替，即地主阶级正在取代旧贵族成为新的地主阶级（但此时自然经济尚不占主导）。这个过程中既产生了大量脱产官僚，又使得统治阶级（因为正在更替）难以形成统一的利益诉求，这为古典官僚体制的形成和君主专制的增强提供了条件。典型古典国家的国家能力非常强大，这意味着其基础性权力达到了

近世以前的最高水平。典型古典国家包括元首制时期的罗马帝国，西汉帝国，印度笈多王朝，后期萨珊帝国，应当包括高棉帝国（但资料太少），某种意义上还包括院政时期的日本。典型古典国家会具有绝大多数古典特征。古典国家因为其官僚体系的强劲我有时也称其为古典官僚国家。

古典官僚体制：即古典官僚国家一般会形成的官僚体制。古典官僚体制的特点在于官员的出身复杂，意识形态多元化，入仕方式多样。虽然古典官僚体制可能形成一套维持自身运行的规则，但是统治者依据个人需求和喜好任免黜陟官员仍然是古典官僚体制运转的主要动力。比起近代国家和现代国家的官僚体制，古典官僚体制的一个特征是选官制度比较简陋。

原生古典国家：经由公元前的大扩张直接形成的古典国家，而不是在更晚的时期在外界的强烈影响下形成的古典国家，只存在于希腊—罗马，波斯，印度和中国。根据观察，基本只有原生古典国家能在某个阶段表现为典型古典国家。

形成期古典国家：特指中国战国时期的大诸侯王国。由于诸夏所主导的大扩张进程发生得比较早，在大扩张的后半段部族和社群已经被大幅消灭了。因此古代中国的封建主义萌芽和阶级交替现象在战国晚期就已经变得十分明显，这成为各诸侯国变法的先决条件，但此时中国尚未统一。

古典社会：典型古典国家所具有的社会形态就是古典社会。

古典时期：狭义的古典时期即典型古典国家存在的历史时期，广义的古典时期向前追溯到典型古典国家的形成期，向后延伸到典型古典国家的崩溃期。在更加不严格的说法下，一些相对落后地区出现的具有某些古典特征的政权存在的时期，也被视为该地区的古典时期。

古典时代晚期（Late Antiquity）：依照西方历史学家的定义。

古典帝国：狭义的古典帝国就是典型古典帝国。广义的古典帝国标准可以宽松，但是至少应该确保其在历史发展序列上不发生错位。这就是说，一旦认定某个政权是古典帝国，那么这个政权建立前当地社会处在的历史阶段不能比古典时期晚，这个政权结束之后当地社会处在的历史阶段不能比古典时期早。例如科尔多瓦哈里发国在伊比利亚建立之前，其实伊比利亚半岛已经封建化了，那么它就不能视为古典帝国，充其量属于一种晚期古典帝国。同样复辟官僚帝国也不属于古典帝国，因为中国北方在南北朝时期已经出现了明显的封建化特征。桑海帝国在被摩洛哥人击溃之后，其统治的范围内不仅没有明显的封建化现象，反而退回了一群早期国家甚至部落林立的状态，不同民间宗教仍然盛行，那么他也不能视为古典帝国，充其量是因为在贸易网络中具有重要地位而高度发达的早期国家。同样匈奴帝国也不能真的被视为古典帝国，因为蒙古地区在之后没有出现过一个古典帝国，而且直到明代后期封建化才比较明显。我把这种判断原则称为序位不变原则，就是在事实上坚持如下观点：哪怕所谓的古典特征有千千万，但是古典时期的本质始终是作为早期国家向封建社会过渡的“过渡时

期”。公认的古典国家应当具有一定数量的古典特征，在我谈到古典帝国的时候一般指的是广义的古典帝国，否则我会强调自己说的是真正的古典帝国。

重冈俊阜：这个词语在汉语里的字面意思是高山。我用它来形容人们对于古典时期和古典帝国所拥有的厚重滤镜，古典辉煌的伟大被过分地夸大了，并且被寄予了太多不切实际的希望。

鼎盛时期的古典帝国或古典帝国的鼎盛时期：当我用这种说法的时候指的是非常非常字面意思的古典国家表面上最强大的历史时期。我唯一想提醒读者的一点是，古典帝国的鼎盛时期和古典社会的存在时期具有差别，一般来讲古典帝国表现最为强大的时代阶级过渡已经基本完成了，封建生产方式占据了主流，因此在时间上要晚于古典社会。帝国之所以还没有因为封建化衰退是因为土地兼并的程度还比较低，自然经济的封建庄园还没有广泛出现。

早期古典国家（帝国）：指在社会尚未发展到古典社会阶段就已经表现出许多古典特征的大帝国。包括波斯阿契美尼德王朝，安息帝国，贵霜帝国（存疑），孔雀王朝等。这种政权的存在基础在于中央对于经济流通的控制以及地方部族和社群的自治。

输入型古典国家：特指中国周边的一系列政权。这些政权自身的社会并未发展到古典社会阶段，但是在中国的影响下过早引入了中国的官僚制度尤指唐代复辟时期的官僚制度，因此表现出了一些古典特征。这类国家包括高句丽、百济、新罗和统一新罗，飞鸟奈良时期的日本，渤海国和南诏。

古典游牧帝国：指匈奴，匈奴属于大扩张这一历史事件在东亚游牧地区发生的外溢，因此具有明显的古典性质。

异常古典国家：指朝鲜半岛的王氏高丽政权。这个国家确实处于古典社会阶段，但是错误地引进了中国的复辟官僚制度。

贸易型伪古典国家：指社会远未发展到古典社会阶段，但是因为该地区在国际贸易中处在关键位置，因此在外界影响下呈现出了一定古典特征。包括阿克苏姆、室利佛逝、可萨汗国、马里和桑海等。这类国家非常脆弱，远非真正的古典国家，一旦其贸易地位丧失或者因为军事失利崩溃，当地社会在很长时间内仍会缺乏封建化迹象。

人地型伪古典国家：指社会远未发展到古典社会阶段，但是因为人地关系失衡，地少人多的情况非常明显，因此初级劳动力作为首位生产要素的地位受到土地的挑战。加之精细化生产和复杂协作需求的出现，该国家呈现出了一定古典特征，特别是官僚体制的异常高度发达。具有代表性的例子是乌尔第三王朝。这类国家不管是从体制，环境还是军事方面来说都是脆弱的。

晚期古典国家：指古典社会结束之后，封建化已经极其明显的历史时期仍然维持部分古典特征，尤其是保留古典官僚体制的国家。这种类型的国家依赖于自身国际贸易中的地

位以及政府对于流通的控制。最典型的晚期古典国家是拜占庭帝国，还至少应该包括科尔多瓦哈里发国，可能包括了孟加拉国的波罗王朝。

蛮族：在古典帝国晚期大举进入文明核心地区各民族的统称，这个名字不代表蛮族相对于古典帝国一定多么落后，只是强调其相对于古典帝国“他者”的身份。蛮族在入关之后引起生产力水平的增长使其具有大量占据土地的需求，因此成为封建化的主力军。

入关：这是一种非常中国化的表述，指的是弱小民族或势力通过军事胜利征服一个大国的过程。

复辟官僚国家：指在古典社会已经完全结束后，封建经济体制已经出现的情况下，因为官僚制度反常的强大导致封建地主阶级没有取得政治上的统治地位，未能进一步向封建领主演化，封建化过程被中断进而倒退，官僚国家重新出现的一种政治状态。复辟官僚国家包括隋唐之后的中国，从中国独立之后的越南，以及朝鲜李朝。

复辟官僚国家与晚期古典国家的本质在于后者在事实上对于封建化缺少应对能力，只能延缓但是无法阻止封建化对于古典官僚体制的冲击，仍然具有解体的倾向。但是复辟官僚国家掌握了完全打压封建地主阶级的政治手段，阻止了大土地所有制的形成，使地主阶级在政治上与被统治阶级同样属于被官僚国家压迫的地位，排除了封建化对于专制君主和官僚政体的威胁，君主的专制性权力在封建经济制度存在的同时极为反常的增强。

复辟官僚制度：复辟官僚国家所实施的官僚制度，从唐至清一直在有所变化并且不断增强。

特别值得注意的是，很多西方研究者都认为复辟官僚制度对于社会剩余的惊人浪费是一种“失策”，但实际上，有计划地销毁社会剩余，使社会生产剩余几乎不产生本身就是复辟官僚制度维持自身存在的手段。因为任何被有效利用的社会生产剩余都有可能带来复辟官僚制度不想看到的变化，这与其维稳的目标是相悖的。然而，官僚体制自身有过度膨胀的属性，复辟官僚体制在全然不受监督的情况下更是如此。因此，复辟官僚体制无法做到生产多少社会剩余就销毁多少。它总会导致这样一个结果，那就是自身销毁的社会财富越来越多，以至于维持社会基本的公共服务和再生产都不可能。一旦感受到危机，复辟官僚制度可能会试图自救，但是每一次自救尝试都使其自身更为庞大，更为具有破坏性。最终的结果是社会进入总崩溃的状态，这也就是中国历史上所谓“王朝周期律”的衰亡部分。

退潮：这是我本人使用的一种描述。它是指某一历史序列中的社会阶段，当然主要是封建社会，在没有自行地演化到向下一个社会阶段运动时，其政治经济制度就开始瓦解的现象。例如隋唐时期的官僚国家复辟，受西方影响下的伊斯兰世界和印度，都可以称作“封建化退潮”。

伪近（现）代化：指完全没有完整经历过封建社会阶段和近世社会阶段的地区仅在西方世界的影响下引进了主要发达国家中世纪盛期以来创造的科学、技术、组织、制度和部分思

想，但是其社会存在对于这些过于先进的舶来品产生了强烈抵制的现象。伪近（现）代化在全世界极为普遍。

宗教教义：宗教教义是指一个宗教的核心信仰，基本原则和世界观。简单来说就是宗教告诉人们应该信什么。

宗教教法：宗教教法是根据宗教教义所制定的、规范信徒行为的法律和规章，是对教义的具体化和应用。教法的作用是指导信徒在日常生活中的行为规范，包括宗教仪式，伦理道德，社会关系等方面。简单来说就是宗教告诉人们应该怎么做。

古典宗教：回应了古典社会的各种诉求，对于各种类型的“古典国家”都有较好适应能力的宗教。以大乘佛教为典型，可能包括了拜火教，早期基督教的一些分支和高棉化的印度教，某种意义上也包含了汉代经学（不过我还是认为儒学不属于宗教）。古典宗教在晚期古典社会可能发生适应性变化，神秘主义倾向和非公开仪式会增加，并且对于君主进行进一步的神化，最为典型的例子是金刚乘佛教，同时应当包含东正教。

封建宗教（封建化宗教）：能够适应封建化这一历史进程的要求，对于封建化早期阶段维系社会的基本流通和技术投资起到重大作用的宗教。相比于古典宗教，封建宗教最大的特点在于深入社会基层，面向人民群众，修行方式简化，强调“因信得救”，教会和教团发达并且积极参与社会活动。典型的封建宗教有天主教、日本佛教和上座部佛教，还应该包括埃塞俄比亚正教，印度教和伊斯兰教的大部分派别，某种意义上还有藏传佛教。但是我想强调的是宗教并非某个社会的本质特征，宗教对于社会存在的变化具有很强的适应性，具体判断的时候不应该望文生义。

封建宗教的结束：随着一个地区从封建社会进入近世社会，世俗的国家机关和各类社会组织都在迅速扩大其能力。近世社会在客观上已经不再需要封建宗教在社会生活中扮演中世纪年代那样重要的作用。宗教因为其固有特征，在协助经济流通和技术投资上的效率已经被近代新生的各种机构所超越。宗教对于社会意识形态的影响也并不利于科学观念在全社会普及。因此在国家向近世转型的时期，各种形式反对封建宗教的运动就必然出现，从最温和的宗教改革到织田信长镇压一揆那样最暴力的活动人们都可以在历史上见到。经过近代化洗礼的宗教在组织上（包括教义和教法两方面）便不会有中世纪那样管理严格，对一般社会生活的参与程度大大下降。当然，就像欧洲宗教改革所表明的，新的教派在道德戒律的要求上可能更严格。在宗教改革时期工商业经济最发达地区出现的新教派，例如基督教新教，在这种意义上可以被称为一种近世宗教。

封建圣战：指在封建宗教的鼓动下，以获得土地并在被征服地区实行封建制度为目的，最终使得征服者转变为统治阶级的战争。最典型的封建圣战是中世纪盛期开始德意志人在波罗的海地区发动的一系列十字军战争。伊斯兰政权所发动的许多吉哈德（Jihad）也具有封建

圣战的性质，但是因为伊斯兰世界的封建化一直不完全，因此从结果看不是那么典型。不是所有拥有宗教圣战口号的敌对行动都属于封建圣战。

古典通语：有的时候是古典通文。指古典帝国官方认定并且在帝国各地广泛使用的一种语言或文字，在古典帝国结束后的封建时期仍然会作为封建宗教教会使用的语言，直到慢慢被封建民族语言取代。

封建民族语言：封建时期所形成的各民族的语言，准确地说，封建民族语言就是日后区别各个民族的主要特征之一。封建民族语言的出现使得古典通语基本退出历史舞台。包括英语、德语、阿姆哈拉语、孟加拉语、泰语等等。

地主-官僚妥协：指蛮族在北中国与汉族地主阶级所达成的一种妥协。少数民族入侵者放弃剥夺汉族地主的土地所有权以实现本民族的封建化，转而使各级酋长转变为各级官僚使本民族官僚化。少数民族中的底层百姓迅速沦落为官僚体制下悲惨的平民，与汉族百姓没有区别，而少数民族统治者则成了专制君主。汉族地主保有了自己的土地并且像过去一样仍然作为官僚参与到国家政治中。这一过程使得北中国的土地所有权乃至土地产权在民族大迁徙的冲击下十分稳定，官僚体制完全没有被封建化摧毁，为官僚复辟国家的形成奠定了基础，是中国封建化失败的主要原因。在伊斯兰征服的过程中可能也出现了类似的现象。

官位荣禄收买：指中国复辟官僚国家刚刚建立的隋唐时期，政府对于作为大土地所有者的门阀士族所采取的暗中削弱措施。统治者授予门阀士族官僚体制中的高位，诱使他们维护官僚体制的权威，向长安和洛阳集中居住，防止其成为土地领主。复辟官僚国家有效地削弱了门阀士族得以形成的基础，即对于生产资料和生产控制，以及基于土地承担军事义务的能力。这种表面上的重视再加上明里暗里的打压使得门阀士族在三个世纪内走向了衰亡，自此中国的地主阶级无法在政治上发出值得关注的声音。

官僚化地主：读者看到这里应该对于这种中华帝国晚期被称为“乡绅”的群体的性质很熟悉了。我把这些概念列出来是想强调，“官僚与地主的对立”与“官僚与地主的密不可分”，在复辟官僚国家是同时存在的现象。对立指的是官僚阻止的地主夺权：地主的正常演进方向是发展为进行政治统治的封建领主，而官僚体制阻止的这一点并将地主纳入自身。这就是演变路径上的对立，而不是结果上的泾渭分明。官僚化地主的社会地位和权利主要来自官僚体系，而非对生产资料的掌控。他们作为次要的经济身份是地主，而主要的政治身份是官僚。

在地领主：在自己所拥有的土地上居住，参与庄园生产管理的封建领主。在地领主具有较强的改良经营方法，提高农业水平的热情和能力。

汉制：指经过第七个皇帝汉武帝刘彻统治时期的更化运动所形成的中国特有的古典官僚体制支持的政治制度。汉制形成于汉匈战争的高潮时期，带有非常浓厚的战时色彩，表现出了极强的动员力和掠夺性。汉制在军事和技术领域的投资非常成功，它在两个世纪内被证明

是一种可怕的战争手段和政府干预推动技术进步及推广的典范。与一般的古典官僚体制不同，汉制下的古典官僚体制赋予了整个官僚系统统一的意识形态和能自行新陈代谢的选官制度及评定、黜陟标准。这导致了一个存在共同价值观念的，通过官僚体制受益的，与官僚体制高度绑定的士大夫阶层的出现。汉制的这些特点在日后成为中国封建化失败，复辟官僚国家重建的重要原因。古典中国结束之前的魏晋政治制度也可以被视为汉制在封建化初期的一种演变。

唐制：即唐代所实施的政治制度，是复辟官僚国家出现之后的里程碑。唐制虽然为当时仍然强大的门阀士族在政治中留有地位，保有大量的封建化特征。但是其最终目的始终是完全消灭封建化对于官僚国家产生的威胁，并且的确有实现目的的能力。唐制因为短期内能够维持很强的军事能力，且意外地能够使用在古典时代和古典时代前的一段时间，对于中国周边造成了极大的破坏。

宋制：即宋代所实施的政治制度，是复辟官僚国家完全成熟的标志。宋制完全消除了封建地主阶级对于复辟官僚体制的威胁，不再为贵族阶层在中国的政治结构中留有任何位置，将整个社会无差别地置于复辟官僚国家的统治之下。但是宋制仍然有在危急时刻释放封建因素以保全自身的灵活性存在。宋制属于中国社会进程演变出的高度特化的政治体制，几乎很难被其他国家学习因此危害较小。

中华帝国晚期：在汉语语境中指的就是明清两代。

本位面：指我们生活的这个真实的世界。

乱纪元：指难以预测的大规模灾难性事件频发的历史时期。

政治效率：指的是一个政治体系（例如国家、政府、政党等）在实现其既定目标或满足社会需求方面的能力和效率。它衡量的是政治体系以最少的资源投入，取得最大成果的能力。

社会存在（social being/social existence）：依照马克思、恩格斯的观点，我在使用时指的是人们在一定历史时期所处的社会物质生活条件的总和，特别是他们的生产方式、生产关系以及这些关系所决定的社会结构。

社会意识（social consciousness）：依照马克思、恩格斯的观点，我在使用时指的是在一定社会存在基础上产生的反应该社会存在的各种思想观念，观点，情感，心理以及表达这些内容的各种形式的总和。有的时候我也把它叫作社会观念。

社会基础：我在使用时指的是构成一个社会正常运作和稳定存在所必要的各种要素和条件的总和。

民智：理性层面的知识以及获取、理解和掌握知识的能力，加上感性层面的情感以及产生，感知和表达情感的能力。

民力：主要指的是以体力劳动为代表的初级劳动力，但是在实际使用的时候不止于此，例如中国统治者驱使百姓投入战争也属于榨取“民力”的一部分，战争显然不属于生产性的劳动。

生产力（productive forces）：依照马克思、恩格斯的观点，我在使用的时候是指特定社会在生产过程中改造自然，获取物质资料的能力。

生产关系（Relations of Production）：依照马克思、恩格斯的观点，我在使用的时候是指人们在生产过程中形成的相互关系，是人们在物质资料的生产，分配，交换和消费过程中所处的地位和相互联系的形式。

经济基础（economic base）：依照马克思、恩格斯的观点，我在使用的时候指的是一定社会中占统治地位的生产关系的总和，是构成社会形态的基础。

上层建筑（superstructure）：依照马克思、恩格斯的观点，我在使用的时候指的是建立在一定经济基础上的，为维护该经济基础服务的各种政治、法律、意识形态和文化设施的总和。

劳动生产率（Labor Productivity）：是一个衡量经济效率的重要指标，它反映了单位劳动投入所产生的产出数量。简单来说，就是衡量工人在单位时间内创造了多少价值或生产了多少产品。

基础性权力（Infrastructural Power）：依照迈克尔·曼（Michael Mann）的观点，它是指国家通过社会基础设施（如法律、行政机构、教育系统、交通网络、通信系统等）渗透和协调社会各个领域的的能力。基础性权力强调制度化、合作性和长期影响。在中华帝国，行使基础性权力的主要是第九章第七节提到的一般行政官僚。因为行使基础性权力让官僚容易通过占有生产资料转化为统治阶级，所以对于最高统治者来说，一般行政官僚最好是流官。

专制性权力（Despotic Power）：依照迈克尔·曼（Michael Mann）的观点，它是指国家统治者在不受制度约束的情况下，随意干预社会生活的能力。专制性权力强调随意性、压制性和短期影响。在中华帝国，行使专制性权力的主要是第九章第七节提到的高度特化的扩大并维护君主利益的官僚。它们高度依附于最高统治者，不容易向统治阶级转化，对于最高统治者来说，这些奴才最好具有世袭性。

中世纪和中世：我在使用欧洲人所说的“中世纪”，日本人所说的“中世”以及“封建社会”这三个概念的时候不做任何区分，他们指的就是一回事。以欧洲的标准来说，大约指的是公元 500 年到公元 1500 年这一千年间的社会形态所界定的时段。有的时候这个概念还被表述为“中古”。

中世纪早期或封建早期：即公元 500 年到公元 1000 年间西欧社会的形态所界定的时段。

中世纪盛期或封建盛期：即公元 1000 年到公元 1300 年间欧洲西部社会的形态所界定的时段。中世纪盛期是社会全面复兴的历史时期，在这个阶段，人口和经济规模等主要社会指标超过古典时期的水平。

中世纪晚期或封建晚期：即公元 1300 年到 1500 年间欧洲西部社会的形态所界定的时段。

近世：也就是“近代”。封建社会瓦解之后到现代社会形成前的历史时期。

近世社会：由封建社会向资本主义社会（现代社会）过渡的一种社会形态，其特征包括民族国家形成，专制主义统治，频繁发动对外战争且军费开支居高不下，经济流通激增，思想解放和科学革命，等级制度瓦解，市民阶层兴起等等。因为西方学者对于他们自己的近代历史早就研究了千百遍，我也不可能有什么补充的。我唯一想强调的就是近世社会具有和古典时期相似的阶级过渡特征，资本取代土地成为首位的生产要素，资产阶级正在代替封建地主阶级成为国家的统治阶级。社会各个阶层力量的相对平衡以及诉求的不一致，成为近世国家绝对君主制能够建立并维持一段时间的社会基础。尽管必然会引起争议，但我坚持把江户时期的日本也划为近世国家。全世界只有极少数国家经历过近代社会，经历过近代社会几乎能够视为成为如今发达国家的先决条件（排除掉袖珍国家。同时承了宗主国宗教、文化、语言特征的原殖民地国家在独立前的历史进程视为与宗主国相同，因为这些原殖民地国家基本复制了宗主国的社会结构）。

绝对君主制：专指在近世社会统治阶级发生过渡的条件下，君主既不受封建制度的制约，又不受资产阶级国家机关的制约形成的君主专制性权力高涨的政治体制。我在使用这个词的时候将其非常严格地限定在近世的君主制国家，以波旁王朝的法国作为代表。任何社会没有到达近世阶段但是君主拥有很大专制性权力的政治体制都不能被视为绝对君主制，不管是奥斯曼帝国，明清帝国，印加帝国还是像现在的文莱、沙特阿拉伯都不行。

绝对主义（Absolutism）国家：与学界通用的定义没有区别。

近世国家：以近世社会为基础建立的国家。君主制的近世国家一般都会在某一时期发展出绝对君主制的特征。有个别近世国家看起来很早就变成了共和国或者是虚君政治（即君主立宪制），但是人们应当注意这些国家本土面积都很小，实际上不存在相对独立的发展进程。它们原本应当是一个更大的近世政权中政治平衡的一部分，也即工商业经济最为发达的地区，但是因为欧洲复杂的政治变动最终独立，荷兰就是这样的。

资本主义：我本人从来没出过国不曾见过，而且这种经济制度出现的社会阶段离中国实在过于遥远，因此无法作出任何评价。就按照学界公认的标准即可。

资本主义社会：同上，我本人难以了解，应当为实行资本主义经济制度并资产阶级占有统治地位的社会。我想说的是资本主义社会在绝大多数运转比较好的地区都建立在当地经历过近世社会的基础上，要么就曾是在地理大发现以后开辟的殖民地。显然绝不是随便一个发展阶段的社会强行移植资本主义经济制度就能够变成资本主义社会。现在我只能看到大韩民

国这样极为罕见的例外，考虑到中国和朝鲜半岛历史进程之间的联系，我认为韩国的成功对于中国来说具有非常大的价值。

资本主义国家：同上，我本人难以了解，基于资本主义社会建立的国家，据我所知资本主义国家的民主程度是有史以来最佳的，这或许正是反映了封建盛期以来社会重组的意义。但是现代社会和资本主义社会究竟能不能等同，似乎并没有定论。

现代社会和现代国家：难以评价，我很难具体知道这两个概念是什么样子。目前看起来资本主义社会就是现代社会的代名词，现代国家就是资本主义国家。

现代性（Modernity）：我基本认同现代性是一种与传统社会相对立的社会发展和文化形态，其核心在于对理性、科学、进步和普遍性的信仰。它起源于欧洲的启蒙运动，并在 19 世纪和 20 世纪逐渐扩展到全球，但是除了发达国家以外，其他地方的社会对现代性的接纳是非常有限的。

后现代性（Postmodernity）：据称，后现代性是对现代性的反思和批判，认为现代性所追求的理性、科学、进步和普遍性都是虚假的，它强调多元、差异、相对性和解构。但是因为我国社会距离现代尚且遥遥无期，因此我并不能够准确理解什么是发达国家认为的后现代性。

欧洲各个部分的界定：据我所知，如何划分西欧、北欧、东欧、南欧和中欧原本就没有统一的标准，对于我一个没有出过国的中国人来说就更加困难。我在讲封建化早期的“西欧”时，一般指的就是西罗马帝国的欧洲，核心是英格兰，法国、北意大利、低地地区和德国西部的一些地区。但是为什么在有的时候又会采用“欧洲西部”这个称呼，原因是历史本来就是动态变化的。一个最简单的例子就是德意志这个概念在中世纪盛期大幅度向东扩张了，如果说公元十世纪的时候说“德国是一个西欧国家”还很合理，但是 1300 年的神圣罗马帝国怎么都更像一个中欧国家。因此我在讲西欧或者欧洲西部的时候其实就是想指封建欧洲的核心地区，这个概念确实在随时间扩大，而东欧、北欧则处于对应方位词所限定的外围地区。

东亚：今天中国、朝鲜、韩国、越南、日本五个国家领土所涵盖的范围。新疆和西藏因为属于中国，所以我也认为它们在东亚地区。但是我在指新疆时会认为它属于“亚洲内陆”，在指西藏时只会说它属于青藏高原的主体。

汉地：即汉族占优势多数的土地。基本上就是清代包括直隶在内的 18 个行省所界定的范围，不包括现在汉族占绝大多数的中国东北地区。在更早的时间段进行描述的时候，像云南贵州这样的地区可能并不被算在汉地里，不过读者一想就能明白，也不影响理解。

中原：中国的文化地理概念，以河南省为中心，向关中、江汉、淮泗、河朔等周边辐射的广大区域，被视为中华民族的摇篮和文明中心。

东北亚：日本、朝鲜、韩国、中国东北地区和俄罗斯远东地区所涵盖的范围，应该跟公认的东北亚是完全一致的。

朝鲜：我在说到朝鲜或者朝鲜人的时候基本指的都是整个半岛或者整个半岛的居民。如果说的是北朝鲜政权，那么结合语义应该非常容易判断。

欧亚大草原：跟学界的定义没有区别。

东南亚：与一般的划分没有区别。不过我有的时候在说东南亚的时候可能是指排除掉华莱士线以东部分以及整个菲律宾的东南亚。

南亚：我在说南亚的时候指的是印度，巴基斯坦，孟加拉国，尼泊尔，不丹，斯里兰卡和马尔代夫这七个国家领土所涵盖的范围，并不包括阿富汗。

中亚：我在说中亚的时候指的是哈萨克斯坦，吉尔吉斯斯坦，塔吉克斯坦，土库曼斯坦，乌兹别克斯坦和阿富汗六个国家，我把阿富汗算作中亚，但是不把新疆算作中亚。

中东：我在说中东的时候指的是被地中海、黑海，大高加索山脉、里海和印度洋所限定，在土耳其、塞浦路斯、埃及和伊朗包围之内的地区，当然也包括这四个国家的领土。

近东：我在说近东这个概念的时候基本上就是指伊斯兰征服前的中东，但是具体包含的地区要小，不包括阿拉伯半岛中南部不邻红海的地区以及除了西南部的伊朗高原（因为伊朗西南部有埃兰文明所以划入近东）。